

Prosperity

The so-called prosperity gospel has not spread only through certain churches. It has also found fertile ground on the internet, across social media, and in the messages of thousands of *influencers* and *coaches* who associate financial success, wealth, and material achievements with God's blessing. In this environment, a dangerous message often takes shape: that anyone who is poor must necessarily have failed because of a lack of faith, discipline, or effort, while those who have prospered financially must therefore be more blessed.

There is nothing wrong with recognizing the value of hard work, responsibility, diligence, or even the desire for a decent and comfortable life. The problem begins when wealth becomes a measure of spirituality and poverty is treated as evidence of moral failure.

This becomes especially troubling when such thinking leads to contempt for the poor. On social media, it is not difficult to find people blaming those living in poverty for their own circumstances, as though all poverty were simply the result of laziness or a lack of initiative. Some even go so far as to argue that the poor should not be helped because they are responsible for what they are going through.

But this way of thinking has to face a simple question:

Does this look anything like Jesus?

The Gospel Does Not Despise the Poor

Jesus never taught his disciples to despise those in need. On the contrary, his life was marked by his closeness to the marginalized, the sick, the poor, and the excluded.

In the Gospel of Luke, Jesus describes his mission by saying:

“The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to bring glad tidings to the poor.”

This is not a minor detail. The poor stand at the heart of Jesus' mission.

On another occasion, when someone asked what he needed to do to follow him, Jesus told him to give his possessions to the poor. He taught his disciples that what we do for the most vulnerable is, in a sense, done to Christ himself.

For this reason, any Christian message about prosperity that ends up producing contempt for the poor must be seriously questioned. It may use religious language, quote Scripture, and constantly speak about God, but that does not mean it reflects the spirit of the Gospel.

Christianity does not turn those in need into enemies.

It does not make the poor guilty simply for being poor.

It does not teach us to look down on those who suffer.

Solomon Is Not the Measure of Every Christian Life

One of the arguments frequently used to defend the prosperity gospel is the example of Solomon. He was an extraordinarily wealthy king, was given great wisdom, and accumulated enormous riches.

But Solomon's life does not allow us to conclude that every servant of God will become wealthy.

The Bible itself presents an enormous diversity of human experiences. Some people received great material prosperity, while others lived in extreme hardship. Some ruled from palaces, while others lived in the wilderness. Some died surrounded by honor, while others were persecuted, imprisoned, tortured, and killed.

Solomon's life, therefore, cannot be turned into a universal formula:

"If you are faithful, you will become rich."

Moreover, Solomon's own story contains a warning. Wealth did not automatically make him a more faithful man. The same man who received extraordinary wisdom eventually allowed power, alliances, and desire to lead his heart astray.

Wealth can be a blessing when it is placed at the service of what is good. But it can also become a trap when it takes the place that belongs to God.

And What About Jesus?

Here we encounter perhaps the greatest difficulty for the prosperity gospel.

If material wealth were the necessary evidence of divine blessing, how are we supposed to explain the life of Jesus?

Jesus was not born in a palace. His family did not belong to Israel's economic elite. During his ministry, he accumulated no property and built no financial empire.

At one point, Jesus said:

“Foxes have dens and birds of the sky have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to rest his head.”

Jesus did not present the accumulation of wealth as the goal of his mission.

He taught about treasure, but pointed toward treasures in heaven. He warned about the danger of trying to serve both God and wealth. He told the story of the rich man who accumulated his possessions and thought he could finally rest, only to discover that his life was coming to an end.

The problem was not simply having money.

The problem was when money had the man.

The Apostles Did Not Live Lives of Luxury Either

After Jesus, the apostles did not suddenly begin living as an economic elite.

Peter and John, when confronted by a man begging for alms, told him that they had neither silver nor gold. Paul knew hunger, thirst, imprisonment, persecution, beatings, and danger. Other disciples faced persecution and death because of their faith.

If financial prosperity were the inevitable consequence of Christian faithfulness, the history of the first followers of Jesus would be one enormous paradox.

They were not spiritually failing because they were persecuted.

They did not lack faith because they suffered.

They were not less blessed because they did not possess great wealth.

Their faithfulness cannot be measured by the size of their possessions.

Moses Died in the Wilderness

The story of Moses itself dismantles the idea that faithfulness always leads, in this life, to receiving what we desire.

Moses led Israel for decades. He confronted Pharaoh, crossed the wilderness, endured the people's complaints, and carried an enormous responsibility.

And yet he never entered the Promised Land.

He died while looking upon it from a distance.

It would be absurd to say that Moses lacked sufficient faith because he did not receive what he had hoped for. His story shows precisely that faithfulness and personal fulfillment are not the same thing.

There are times when a person can devote an entire lifetime to a mission without personally witnessing its final outcome.

That does not make his life a failure.

John the Baptist Did Not End in Prosperity Either

John the Baptist is another deeply unsettling example for any doctrine that turns material success into a sign of divine approval.

He lived simply in the wilderness, preaching repentance. He did not build a luxurious career. He did not accumulate wealth. He did not seek prestige.

His faithfulness led him to prison and, eventually, to death.

John lost his head for denouncing the sin of a ruler.

If we applied the logic of the prosperity gospel to the life of John the Baptist, we would have to conclude that he failed.

But Jesus did not present John as a failure.

Quite the opposite. Jesus spoke of him with extraordinary praise.

That should make us stop and think.

Jesus in the Wilderness

There is another episode that is especially important: Jesus' temptation in the wilderness.

The devil offers Jesus power, glory, and the kingdoms of this world.

The proposal is remarkably revealing: greatness without the path of obedience and sacrifice.

Jesus rejects it.

He refuses to exchange his mission for the power of the kingdoms of the world.

Here we find a fundamental difference between the Gospel and a materialistic understanding of faith.

The Gospel asks:

“Who are you becoming before God?”

A corrupted prosperity mindset asks:

“How much have you managed to conquer?”

One looks at character.

The other can end up looking at net worth.

The Danger of Turning God into a Means of Getting Rich

We must be careful, however, not to fall into the opposite extreme.

The problem is not having money.

A Christian can be wealthy and still be generous, humble, and deeply devoted to God. The Bible does not teach that every form of wealth is sinful.

The problem begins when God is reduced to a means of becoming rich.

When prayer becomes a technique for obtaining money.

When giving is presented as a financial investment that is guaranteed to produce a material return.

When a poor person is told that their poverty exists because they have not had enough faith.

When someone's success is used as proof that they are spiritually superior.

At that point, faith stops being a relationship with God and begins to look like a transaction.

“I give to God, and God gives it back to me multiplied.”

This logic is dangerous because it turns the Creator into some kind of reward mechanism.

God is no longer loved for who he is. He is pursued for what he can provide.

True Prosperity

Perhaps we need to recover the meaning of the word *prosperity*.

To prosper should not simply mean to accumulate.

A person can have very little money and still have a life rich in love, friendship, dignity, wisdom, and purpose.

Another person may have millions and live as a slave to anxiety, greed, fear of losing everything, and the constant need to accumulate more.

Which one is truly prosperous?

The prosperity presented by the Gospel cannot be reduced to a bank balance.

It involves a life reconciled with God, human relationships marked by love, a clear conscience, generosity, justice, compassion, and a willingness to share.

Jesus did not say that we would be recognized by the size of our bank accounts.

He said we would be recognized by our love.

Money Must Serve the Human Person

Money is a tool.

It can feed a family, fund a school, build a home, support a social project, help someone in need, and provide decent living conditions.

But it can also become a master.

When that happens, people begin sacrificing everything to preserve and increase their wealth.

Relationships are destroyed.

People are exploited.

The dignity of workers is sacrificed.

The poor are despised.

Conscience becomes negotiable.

And, in the end, a person may discover that he has accumulated a great deal of money but lost the things that truly mattered.

Jesus summed up this danger forcefully when he asked what profit there is for a man to gain the whole world and lose his own soul.

Against Cruelty in the Name of God

Something even more serious happens when the prosperity gospel is used to justify cruelty.

Telling a hungry person that he is poor because he is lazy is a cruel oversimplification.

There are poor people who work tirelessly.

There are people born into environments of extreme inequality.

There are families affected by war, economic crises, illness, unemployment, abandonment, exploitation, and countless other circumstances that cannot be reduced to an alleged lack of individual effort.

A Christian is not called to investigate whether someone in need “deserves” help before showing mercy.

The parable of the Good Samaritan does not ask, “Does this wounded man deserve help?”

The Samaritan simply saw him, was moved with compassion, and cared for him.

That is the logic of the Gospel.

Who Is the Author of the Prosperity Gospel?

It is tempting to summarize everything by saying that “the devil is the author of the prosperity gospel.” The statement expresses an understandable theological criticism: the account of Jesus’ temptation itself shows Satan offering Jesus the kingdoms and glory of the world.

However, an important distinction must be made.

We should not automatically attribute everything someone teaches wrongly to Satan. Human responsibility remains. People create, spread, and defend doctrines; Churches can interpret them incorrectly; leaders can manipulate faith for their own benefit.

The central question is not to identify a single culprit.

It is to discern the spirit behind the message.

If a preacher turns money into the center of Christian life, humiliates the poor, transforms faith into a mechanism for personal enrichment, and places accumulation above compassion, that message must be confronted with the Gospel.

Because the Christ we encounter in Scripture did not teach his disciples to despise the poor.

He taught them to serve them.

He did not teach that a person’s value depends on his possessions.

He taught that a person’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.

He did not promise his followers a life without suffering.

He promised his presence.

A Prosperity That Cannot Be Bought

Perhaps the greatest form of Christian wealth is precisely the kind that cannot be bought.

Peace is not for sale.

Love cannot be purchased in a store.

Forgiveness cannot be bought.

Character cannot be paid for in installments.

Wisdom does not necessarily come with money.

And eternal life is not a financial reward.

Christian prosperity needs to be rediscovered as a life whose value is found in God, not in what we possess.

We can work to improve our circumstances.

We can desire a dignified life.

We can build companies, develop projects, make money, and enjoy the honest fruits of our labor.

But none of this should make us forget those who have been left behind.

If our prosperity does not produce generosity, perhaps it is not prosperity.

If our wealth produces contempt, perhaps we have become materially richer while becoming spiritually poorer.

If our success requires us to humiliate those who have failed, perhaps we have conquered the world but lost our hearts.

The true Christian challenge is not simply to become rich.

It is to learn how to use what we have without allowing what we have to turn us into people who are poor in love.

Because, in the end, the question of the Gospel will not simply be how much we accumulated.

It will be what we did with what we were given.

And perhaps that is true prosperity: having enough to live with dignity, enough to share, and a heart free enough to understand that no fortune in this world is worth more than a life transformed by love.